

lunches to kids' fundraisers and those dang Girl Scout Cookies, it's possible to spend a good chunk of change we weren't planning on each month.

Thankfully, you're capable of doing hard things! You can remind yourself of your values and what they mean for your spending. You can check in with the parameters you've set for your money and communicate your chosen action. While it may absolutely mean buying that box of Tagalongs (because that chocolate peanut butter cookie combo is fire), it could also mean opting out of the happy hour, or vice versa. Since this can be a tricky thing to navigate in the moment, let's review some of your options so you feel well-equipped to handle the next request that conflicts with your financial goals.

For the lunch or happy hour invite that is not in your spending plan, remember that "no" is a full sentence. You can choose to opt out. You can catch the next one. You can go and order in a way that makes sense for you. Or you can be the initiator of the plans with suggestions like BYO lunch to the local park (we like this because it doesn't limit others from getting takeout if they want!), coffee walks in the morning before work instead of drinking after, or invitations to free activities. We love city websites and the Facebook events section for finding the cool stuff.

For the pooled gift money that just doesn't make the cut on your priorities list, offer an alternative like being the one to pick up and write the card, order the flowers, or decorate the desk. Your sweat equity and investment of time may be just as valuable as the \$20 they were hoping to gather. Depending on your comfort level, you may also choose to share some of the financial choices you are making and why. If you're currently engaging in a no-spend challenge, say it! If you're prioritizing paying off a student loan or credit card and these small decisions are helping you get there, let them know! Oftentimes this is inspirational to others and gives space for them to choose intentional spending.

With Our Internet Friends

Many of us are finding like-minded, helpful individuals and groups digitally. Whether it's a hobby, sport, or area of learning, we get to gather and find connections with others from different parts of the world. There's